

Competitive Analysis

PACER, FBI Crime Data Explorer (CDE), and SLED CATCH

Crime Information & Investigation Systems Review

Introduction

Law enforcement agencies, researchers, legal professionals, and the general public increasingly rely on digital crime and court information systems to access criminal records, court filings, crime statistics, and investigative data. Three major systems currently used in the United States are PACER, FBI Crime Data Explorer (CDE), and SLED CATCH.

1. PACER (Public Access to Court Electronic Records)

Overview:

PACER is the federal judiciary's electronic public access system for retrieving court records, docket information, case filings, and judicial opinions.

Advantages:

- Massive federal database
- Real-time court updates
- Comprehensive legal information
- Public transparency

Disadvantages:

- Outdated user interface
- Paywall concerns
- Complex search structure
- Not beginner friendly

Implications:

Our system should prioritize modern UI/UX, advanced search filtering, centralized dashboards, and accessible navigation.

2. FBI Crime Data Explorer (CDE)

Overview:

The FBI Crime Data Explorer provides crime statistics collected through the FBI's UCR and NIBRS systems.

Advantages:

- Strong data visualization
- Nationwide crime data
- Transparency and public access
- Downloadable datasets

Disadvantages:

- Limited individual record access
- Reporting inconsistencies

- Complexity for casual users

Implications:

Our system should combine interactive dashboards with searchable individual records and simplified analytics.

3. SLED CATCH (South Carolina Citizens Access to Criminal Histories)

Overview:

SLED CATCH is South Carolina’s online criminal background check platform managed by the South Carolina Law Enforcement Division.

Advantages:

- Simple criminal record access
- Public accessibility
- Fast search functionality

Disadvantages:

- Limited geographic coverage
- Basic interface
- Minimal advanced analytics

Implications:

Our platform should combine simplicity with modern analytics and broader multi-jurisdictional coverage.

Feature Comparison Table

Feature	PACER	FBI CDE	SLED CATCH
Court Records Access	Yes	No	Limited
Criminal Background Checks	No	No	Yes
Crime Statistics	Limited	Yes	Limited
Dashboards	Limited	Yes	No
Visualization	Basic	Strong	Minimal
Public Access	Yes	Yes	Yes
Coverage	Federal	Nationwide	South Carolina
Search by Name	Yes	No	Yes
Filtering	Moderate	Strong	Basic
Ease of Use	Low	Moderate	High

Summary of Implications

PACER, FBI Crime Data Explorer, and SLED CATCH each provide valuable capabilities for crime and legal information management, but each also contains significant limitations. PACER excels in court record depth but lacks modern usability. FBI Crime Data Explorer offers excellent visual analytics but lacks detailed investigative tools. SLED CATCH provides easy criminal background searches but lacks advanced analytics and broader geographic coverage. The ideal crime information system would combine: • PACER's legal and court record depth • FBI CDE's analytics and visualization • SLED CATCH's accessibility and simplicity Our platform should prioritize modern UI/UX, searchable records, interactive dashboards, advanced filtering, and centralized crime information access.

Referenced Websites

- <https://pacer.uscourts.gov/>
- <https://cde.ucr.cjis.gov/LATEST/webapp/#!/pages/home>
- <https://catch.sled.sc.gov/>